

The Lost Art of Doing Nothing

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Essay

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How boredom, bad farts, and the absence of Wi-Fi accidentally raised functional human beings.

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The Lost Art of Doing Nothing

We used to stare at ceilings.

Not because we were meditating. Not because some parenting expert had discovered the developmental benefits of drywall contemplation. We stared at ceilings because there was nothing else to do, and nobody in the house cared enough about our boredom to treat it like a crisis.

You would lie on the floor, or on your bed, or across the couch in a position that would now require a chiropractor and two insurance pre-authorizations, and you would just look up. Maybe there was a water stain shaped vaguely like a horse. Maybe the ceiling fan had one blade that wobbled like it had seen things. Maybe the popcorn ceiling had enough little bumps in it to form entire civilizations if you stared long enough and were mentally unstable enough, which, to be fair, we all were by about the third week of summer vacation.

And somehow, from this sad little arrangement of boredom, heat, and no adult intervention, we developed personalities.

That is the part that seems impossible now.

Right now, boredom is treated like a medical emergency. A child sits in silence for eight seconds, looks around the room, finds no glowing rectangle, and immediately begins behaving like a pioneer whose oxen have died three miles outside of Oregon. Their eyes go wide. Their breathing changes. A faint moral accusation enters the room. “There’s nothing to do,” they say, as if announcing a famine.

And then the parents pay for it.

Because modern boredom does not stay inside the bored person. Oh no. It spreads. It becomes everyone’s problem. It walks into the kitchen while you are trying to cook dinner and asks what you are doing. It follows you to the garage. It asks if the Wi-Fi is down. It complains that the internet is slow, as if the family has failed at basic civilization. It hovers over your shoulder while you answer an email and sighs with the full emotional weight of a French widow staring at the sea.

I don’t want to sound like one of those people who believes childhood peaked with lawn darts and mild dehydration. There was plenty about growing up in the 1980s and 90s that was not exactly enlightened. Bike helmets were apparently for visiting dignitaries. Sunscreen was something your mom remembered after you had already become medium-well. Seatbelts were often treated as a suggestion, like flossing or respecting the speed limit. We drank from garden hoses, rode in truck beds, and ate snacks made mostly of corn syrup, red dye, and whatever chemical gave fruit punch its faintly radioactive confidence.

So no, I am not saying everything was better.

But boredom was better.

Or at least boredom had a job.

During the summer, boredom was not something my parents were expected to solve. It was something we were expected to survive. I remember being kicked outside for the day unless we wanted to be put through chore hell. And chore hell was not some cute family productivity system with a laminated chart and a reward sticker. Chore hell meant baseboards, weeds, garage sweeping, bathroom cleaning, or being handed a rag and a bottle of

something that smelled like regret. You learned quickly that the outdoors, with all its bugs, heat, gravel, and questionable neighbor kids, was still the better deal.

So we hopped on our bikes and disappeared.

Not dramatically. Not like missing children on a milk carton. Just normal kid disappeared. We rode around the neighborhood like tiny unpaid postal workers with no route and no purpose. We went to the woods. We went to the lake. We went to the school playground. We went wherever our legs and stupidity could take us.

We did not come home until dusk, or until we could hear Mom honking the car horn and yelling that we better get our asses home. That sound was the original location-sharing app. No GPS. No Life360. No gentle notification that “Rob has arrived at The Place Where He Is Probably Doing Something Dumb.” Just a horn blast cutting through the evening air and a maternal voice carrying enough force to scatter birds.

And we came home.

Mostly.

The woods were where boredom became something else. We built huts and forts with the neighbor kid using whatever we could find: sticks, plywood, old carpet pieces, mysterious buckets, and scraps of material that probably should have required a tetanus shot just to look at them. The engineering was not great. Most of our forts were one gust of wind away from becoming an insurance claim. But to us they were headquarters, rebel bases, outlaw camps, military bunkers, secret labs, and occasionally homes for imaginary families who had made a series of poor real estate decisions.

We acted out action movies we were absolutely too young to have watched. We were commandos. We were cops. We were ninjas. We were survivors of vague but intense disasters. We dove behind logs. We made explosion noises with our mouths. We said bad words we were not supposed to say. Sorry, Mom. We developed entire storylines that made no sense, involved seventeen betrayals, and usually ended with someone arguing about whether they were actually shot or just “barely grazed.”

Only we knew what happened out there.

That mattered.

There was no camera. No post. No group chat. No record of the bad accents, bad language, bad ideas, or bad karate. We got to be ridiculous in private. We got to try on personalities like costumes. We got to be brave, obnoxious, dramatic, sneaky, noble, loud, weird, and dumb without having it stored somewhere by a company that also wanted to sell us socks.

That is not a small thing.

Kids need private foolishness. They need the freedom to be idiots without becoming content. They need to say something dumb in the woods, have their friends call them an idiot, and then move on with their lives. They need to build a fort that collapses, invent rules to a game nobody understands, get bored, get mad, get creative, get over it, and come home dirty enough that their mothers question the entire concept of motherhood.

Boredom gave us room to become people before anyone was watching.

That is where the funny part starts to get less funny.

Because I look at kids now, including my own, and I don't think they are worse people. I really don't. I think they are growing up in a world that has quietly robbed them of the space where imagination used to grow. And then, in true Rob fashion, we blame them for not having enough imagination.

We gave them screens early. We gave them endless options. We gave them streaming, gaming, scrolling, short videos, faster internet, smarter phones, algorithmic everything, and the ability to summon entertainment instantly from a rectangle they can hold in one hand while refusing to put on socks with the other. Then we act shocked when silence feels unbearable to them.

To be fair, we adults are not exactly innocent here. We check our phones in grocery lines. We listen to podcasts while doing dishes. We scroll while watching TV, which is an insane sentence if you step back and look at it for even half a second. We have entertainment playing while we avoid other entertainment because the first entertainment was not entertaining enough. We are not monks over here. We are just older addicts with mortgages and lower battery capacity.

But still, something has changed.

When I was bored, my mind had to make something. It had to invent a world or a game or a story or a plan. Sometimes it invented trouble, for sure. Boredom is not always noble. Sometimes boredom creates art, and sometimes it creates a kid throwing apples at a stop sign because the sound is funny or burning something in a coffee can out in the woods because I was told not to play with fire religiously. I'm not trying to put a halo on childhood stupidity. Some of it was just stupidity.

But even stupidity required participation.

Now boredom gets outsourced. The first twinge of emptiness gets handed to a device. A kid does not have to sit with the weird ache of having nothing to do. They do not have to push through the first miserable layer of boredom, the part where everything seems stupid and every suggestion from a parent sounds like a human rights violation. They can skip straight to stimulation.

And when you skip boredom, you also skip what boredom can turn into.

A cardboard box becomes nothing but recycling if nobody is bored enough to make it a spaceship. A stick is just a stick if nobody needs it to be a sword, a staff, a fishing pole, a microphone, or a high-powered laser rifle with terrible sound effects. A patch of woods is just trees if nobody has the time and mental vacancy to turn it into a kingdom, a battlefield, a haunted forest, or the site of a very serious neighborhood government with one president, two spies, and no clear tax policy.

Imagination is not magic. It is not something that floats down from the clouds and lands gently on children who have been enrolled in the right enrichment program. It grows in empty space. It grows when nothing is happening and nobody is coming to fix it.

That is the moral problem underneath all the complaining.

Because boredom does more than entertain kids after they suffer through it. It teaches them that their own minds are not useless. It teaches them that discomfort is not always danger. It teaches them that being unstimulated for a few minutes will not kill them, despite all available evidence from the back seat of the car indicating otherwise.

It also teaches them patience with themselves.

There is a kind of quiet confidence that comes from knowing you can make something out of nothing. Not a product. Not content. Not a personal brand. Just something. A story. A game. A joke. A plan. A dumb little fort that leans to the left but is yours. When everything is provided instantly, kids may become very good at choosing. But choosing is not the same as creating.

And that, I think, is where a lot of us parents are stuck.

We want our kids to be creative, but we are terrified of letting them be bored. We want them to be resilient, but we rush to remove the tiny discomforts that build resilience. We want them to have personalities, but we hand them devices that flatten every quiet moment before it can become a thought.

I say this with guilt, not superiority. I have handed over the screen. I have enjoyed the blessed silence that comes when a child is absorbed in something digital and not asking me why dinner takes so long or whether we own a flamethrower. I have used Wi-Fi as a parenting assistant. Many times. Super happy to admit it, because lying about it would be pointless and also my children have witnesses.

But at the end of the day, I know the difference between a tool and a pacifier. And sometimes, if we are being honest, the screens are pacifiers. Not just for them. For us.

The hard part is that boredom is noisy at first. A bored kid is not a peaceful kid. A bored kid is a customer service complaint with legs. They roam the house looking for someone to blame. They open the refrigerator like meaning might be hiding behind the ketchup. They flop onto furniture with the despair of a bankrupt railroad baron. They ask questions they do not actually want answered. They make noises that seem designed by scientists to test adult sanity.

Then, if nobody rescues them, something happens.

Not always. Sometimes they just remain irritating. Let's not get carried away.

But sometimes the boredom breaks. They go outside. They pick up a ball. They draw something. They invent a game with rules so complex and unfair that Congress would be impressed. They start building something. They start pretending. They start talking to each other. They start fighting, which is not ideal, but still technically interpersonal development.

They become active instead of entertained.

That shift matters. It is the difference between being fed and learning how to cook, between watching someone else be funny and finding out whether you are, between consuming a story and making one, between having a personality delivered by algorithm and developing one the old-fashioned way, through weirdness, embarrassment, conflict, silence, trial and error, and the occasional bad word in the woods.

Sorry again, Mom.

I am not calling for some dramatic family revolution where we smash the routers, burn the tablets, and send children into the wilderness with a canteen and a pocketknife. That sounds exhausting, and I still need Google Maps like everyone else. I am not anti-technology. I like technology. I like air conditioning, online shopping, and being able to settle a family argument about who played the villain in a 1993 movie before it becomes Thanksgiving-ruining material.

The issue is not that screens exist.

The issue is that they have become the first answer to every empty moment.

Maybe kids need more empty moments. Maybe adults do too. Maybe we all need to remember what it feels like to stare at a ceiling long enough for the ceiling to become boring, then interesting, then weirdly meaningful, then boring again. Maybe we need to stop treating silence like a malfunction.

Because a child who can be bored without panicking has a gift. A child who can make a game out of sticks and dirt has something no app can provide. A child who has private space to be ridiculous, to imagine, to fail, to say something dumb and survive it, is not wasting time.

They are becoming a person.

We did not know that when we were kids. We thought we were just avoiding chores. And to be fair, we were absolutely avoiding chores. Let the historical record show that if given the choice between character formation and scrubbing a toilet, we chose character formation with impressive speed.

But out there on the bikes, in the woods, under the trees, inside those crooked forts, with dusk coming on and somebody's mom honking in the distance, boredom was doing its strange little work.

It was giving us room.

I just want our kids to have some room too.